



The influence of social media influencer (SMI) and social influence on purchase intention among young consumers

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ABSTRACT

The implications of social media influencers (SMI) are more important than ever, specifically considering online purchasing has become a trend, more so as a result of the COVID-19 pandemic. In this respect, brands must employ social media influencers to attract customers, and who needs be more creative than traditional advertisers in generating purchase intent. In this context, our study employed the TEARS model (i.e. trustworthiness, expertise, attractiveness, respect, similarity) and the social influence theory to understand the predictors of consumer purchase intention. Our study aimed to examine: (1) the characteristics of social media influencers (i.e. trustworthiness, expertise, attractiveness, respect, similarity) as predictors of intention to purchase, and (2) the relationship between social influence and purchase intention among Gen Z. A total of 605 useable responses were collected. The study findings suggest that the four dimensions of the TEARS Model were established as predictors for purchase intention among Gen Z consumers with the exception of "Respect". Besides, informational and normative influence were significant predictors of purchase intention. The study adds to the growing body on SMI impact by revealing the elements that influence Gen Z's purchase intention. Our findings also shed further light on the understanding of the social influence theory and TEARS Model in a collectivist culture, particularly in the SMI context.

Keywords: *Social media influencer (SMI), TEARS model, social influence, purchase intention, Gen Z*

INTRODUCTION

The recent COVID-19 pandemic radically impacted our lifestyles and social norms as a result of social distancing measures and standard operating procedures (SOP) imposed by governments, and even marketers and businesses have transformed the way they communicate and interact with customers. Moreover, many service firms suffered great financial losses and came close to closing down (Kadirov et al., 2020). In this regard, the Malaysian government encouraged businesses to shift to online platforms and online purchase to help keep local businesses afloat. Further, reports show that 70% of Malaysians spend time on social media (Koh, 2020). As a result of social distancing measures such as lockdowns, consumers who were confined to their homes became reliant on social media and digital platforms for work and business purposes as well as to remain connected to the wider society.

According to Lipizzi et al. (2015), social media influencers' (SMI) content, also known as user generated content, is considerably more successful than professional advertising. It is attributable to the collaborative process of product-related sharing of information and knowledge exchange between SMIs and consumers, which benefits brands indirectly (Merz et al., 2018; Shi et al., 2016). SMIs also help promote products by providing video reviews. Furthermore, many people who broadcasted live on social media to promote the products they used throughout the lockdown, may be considered as influencers. This suggests that an increasing number of people are participating in influencer marketing, which has resulted in increased sales. This also demonstrates that the shift from conventional word-of-mouth (WOM) to electronic word-of-mouth (eWOM) (Cheung et al., 2021; Sharipudin et al., 2023).

Our study aims to investigate the influence of social media influencers and social influence on purchase intention among generation Z (Gen Z) in Malaysia. Employing the social influence theory and the TEARS model (i.e. Trustworthiness, Expertise, Attractiveness, Respect, Similarity), we looked at the determinant factors that affect purchase intention among Gen Z. Shimp (2003) stated that the "TEARS " model comprises two main components that motivate SMIs' effectiveness, which are credibility (trustworthiness and expertise) and attractiveness (attractiveness, respect and similarity). With these attributes, SMIs can persuade their followers or consumers to purchase the product recommended or introduced by the SMIs.

Past studies have demonstrated that social influence has an impact on the consumer decision - making process (Hageböling et al., 2021), impulsive buying behaviour (Aragoncillo & Orus, 2018; Silvera et al., 2008), and purchase decision behaviour (Aragoncillo & Orus, 2018), especially in collectivistic cultural contexts (Hanif et al., 2022; Khare, 2015; Peng et al., 2019; Zhao et al., 2019). Based on the above discussion, the following research questions were formulated: 1) are characteristics of social media influencers (i.e. trustworthiness, expertise, attractiveness, respect, similarity) predictors of intention to purchase? and 2) does social influence have an impact on the purchase intention of generation Z (Gen Z)?

LITERATURE REVIEW

Social media influencer and consumer decision behaviour

Generally, both celebrity endorsement and social media influencer (SMI) are considered as influencer marketing. Celebrity endorsement is regarded as the first type of influencer to emerge while SMIs developed during the era of digital conversion. Freberg et al. (2011) highlighted that in the digital world, besides celebrities, social media influencers have also

emerged as dynamic third-party endorsers in significant numbers. Besides, the number of key opinion leaders (KOLs) is also rising as social media has rapidly become an efficient marketing tool along with e-commerce platforms to maximise business profit and consumer engagement. The rise of KOLs is a trend that brands or marketers have embraced as trusted figures can change people's view regarding a product and can therefore be considered as advertising in a conventional manner (Lazarsfeld, 1940).

However, there are some slight differences between influencers and KOLs. The first aspect is that the influencer's content is based on viral trends while KOLs will focus on content that is relevant to their expertise or field. From the aspect of engagement, KOLs have a higher engagement rate than influencers due to the KOLs having niche markets that indirectly lead to a more loyal and dedicated fan base. In short, KOLs can be classified as SMIs who use their own opinion, expertise or knowledge to influence others in terms of purchase intention. According to Linqia (2020), 74% of marketers will initiate influencer campaigns and possibly even more than they did pre-pandemic, once quarantines have been lifted.

Previous studies have made comparisons between celebrity and influencer endorsements. For instance, Thornton (2018) who conducted a content analysis on Instagram found that influencer content is generally more intimate than celebrity content because influencers encourage their followers to reach out in the comments or engage with them at public meet-ups. In addition, the study also found that influencers place the community before their own agenda whereas celebrities use social media beyond interpersonal connections such as for movie promotions and more.

A study by Schouten et al. (2020) also found that the consumer identifies and feels more strongly with influencers, thus trusts them more than celebrities. It could be argued that consumers ascribe a higher credibility to SMIs since the latter are perceived as normal users like anyone else on social media, but they are more famous due to their number of followers (Abidin & Ots, 2015). Meanwhile, Lim and Goh (2019) found that consumer attitude is the most influential predictor for consumer purchase intention. Hence, marketers should be more alert when choosing SMIs since the appropriate social media influencer can boost consumer purchase intention.

Social influence and consumer decision behaviour

Kelman (1961) stated that the three stages that lead to changes in an individual are compliance, integration, and identification. The notion of accepting information from experts or others as genuine truth is known as informational, while those based on a sense of belonging and obtaining good evaluations from individuals in a given group and community are known as social norms (Kaplan & Miller, 1987). As individuals, we are inclined to be affected by someone else, leading to changes in one's behaviours, action, belief, and more. As the world is rapidly digitalising, social media has become a vital tool for businesses to advertise their brands to their customers. In this context, individuals close to an individual significantly influence that individual's technology usage (Venkatesh et al., 2003).

Several studies have found that social influence has an impact on consumer decision-making. Wiedmann et al. (2010) showed, for example, that other consumers, particularly those in the same social network, had a significant impact on their preferences. This demonstrates how informational and normative factors might influence a consumer's purchase behaviour. Furthermore, social influence, whether normative or informational, plays a significant role in consumer decision-making (Hageböling et al., 2021), impulsive buying behaviour (Aragoncillo & Orus, 2018; Silvera et al., 2008), and purchase decision behaviour (Aragoncillo & Orus, 2018).

Previous studies found that social influence has a significant impact on consumers' decision behaviour in a collectivistic cultural context. For instance, Hanif et al. (2022) discovered that social influence has a substantial impact on male and female mobile buying behaviour. Similarly, Peng et al. (2019) found that customer purchase intention on an online platform in Taiwan are influenced by normative social influence. Using online questionnaires, Zhao et al. (2019) investigated how Chinese consumers are persuaded by their peers to support or purchase sustainable products. According to the study's findings, Chinese consumers' buying intentions for environmentally sustainable garments might be rational or purposeful. Khare (2015) noted that social influence is a predictor of good green purchase decisions. As previously stated, social influence may impact a person's behaviour or purchasing intention based on their amount of closeness or confidence in that individual, particularly in a collectivist cultural context.

The relationship between the trustworthiness of social media influencers and purchase intention

In online platforms, trust is a critical component, especially when the consumer wants to enquire or learn more about a product (Li et al., 2012). Additionally, trust has a considerable influence on customer buying intentions, according to Hsiao et al. (2010). Furthermore, according to Uzunoğlu and Misci Kip (2014), SMIs' trustworthiness may boost the credibility of a brand amongst a large audience or a high number of followers, whilst Pick (2021) contended that trustworthiness is one of the essential criterion that would lead to consumer purchase intention. Therefore, it is hypothesised:

H1a: The higher the degree of trustworthiness of SMI, the greater the possibility of purchase intention.

The relationship between the expertise of social media influencers and purchase intention

The SMIs' influential power is measured by the amount of attention they receive from their followers through interactions, which means that the more attention they receive, the more influential power they wield (Li et al., 2012). The degree of knowledge held by the SMI is crucial in influencing the consumer's buying intention (Yadav et al., 2013). Ohanian (1991) found a similarity in his research, demonstrating that customer purchase intent is linked to endorser skill. Other studies highlighted that SMI competence is one of the factors that contributes to SMI efficacy in influencing customer purchase intent (Pick, 2021; Utami, 2019). Furthermore, Kapitan and Silvera (2016) recognised SMI as a person with product expertise that leads to customer purchase. Similarly, Lis (2013) discovered that the more advanced the SMI's knowledge, the more probable the customer will develop a purchase intention owing to the trustworthiness of product information. Therefore, we posit that:

H1b: The higher the degree of SMI expertise as perceived by consumers, the greater the possibility of purchase intention.

The relationship between the attractiveness of social media influencers and purchase intention

According to Erdogan (1999), the physical characteristics or attributes of an endorser form the main aspect of beauty. Previous research has demonstrated that the attractiveness of SMIs influences customer purchase intent, particularly in the fashion and cosmetics

industries (Utami, 2019). Furthermore, according to Till and Busler (2000), the appealing properties of SMIs have a beneficial impact on customer purchase intention. Further, the attractiveness of SMIs has recently been revealed to considerably boost customer purchase intention (Weismueller et al., 2020). Hence, we suggest that:

H1c: The higher the degree of attractiveness of the SMI as perceived by consumers, the higher the possibility of purchase intention.

The relationship between consumers' respect for social media influencers and purchase intention

According to Shimp (2003), a celebrity's personal accomplishments can lead to esteemed reputation and admiration, and therefore can be classified as respect. Byrne et al. (2003) also stated that respect can be equated to likability due to the traits or behaviour of the endorser. Previous studies also found that respect can significantly affect consumer purchase intention (Ahmad et al., 2019; Hollensen & Schimmelpfennig, 2013). Therefore, we hypothesise that:

H1d: The more the consumers respect the SMI, the higher the possibility of purchase intention.

The relationship between consumers' similarities with social media influencers and purchase intention

According to Kaplan and Haenlein (2010), the messages shared by SMIs about their everyday lives has an influence on their social status and also has an impact on the consumer or followers. Li et al. (2014) contended that persons with similar interests are much more likely to influence an individual's purchasing intention than those with opposing views. When a consumer inspires to achieve the same image or reputation of an SMI, they will likely buy the product or brand that the SMI consumes (Nejad et al., 2014). Hence, we suggest that:

H1e: The more similarities that consumers perceive with the SMI, the higher the possibility of purchase intention.

The relationship between social influence and purchase intention

Several studies have found that social influence has an effect on customer attitude, behaviour, and preference. Youn and Jin (2017), for example, proved that social influence is a strong predictor of customer purchase intent. Furthermore, according to Kim and Johnson (2015), close relationships with family and friends are two key factors that impact a consumer's purchase intentions. The majority of research also demonstrate that social influence affects consumer decisions, particularly in collectivist countries, where people tend to follow the majority (Hanif et al., 2022; Khare, 2015; Peng et al., 2019; Zhao et al., 2019). Thus, the following set of hypotheses are proposed:

H2a: Informational influence can positively influence purchase intention.

H2b: Normative influence can positively influence purchase intention.

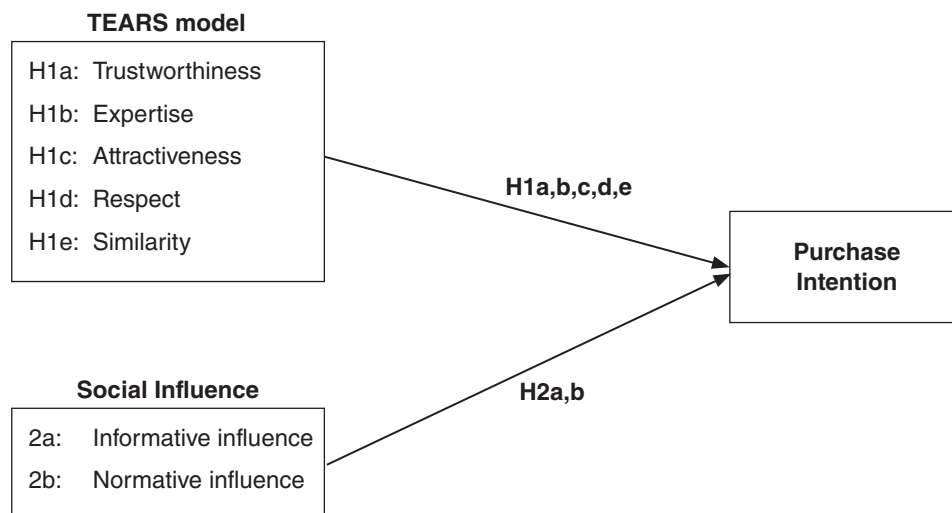


Figure 1. Conceptual model

METHODOLOGY

Data collection

A self-administered online survey was used to collect the study data. Due to time and cost restrictions, data collection was carried out at Malaysia's main public educational institutions. The respondents consisted of undergraduate students, selected using simple random sampling, so that each individual had an equal opportunity to participate in this study. The sample focused on young consumers in Malaysia, notably Gen Z. In Malaysia, the young generation form the bulk of the population (Department of Statistics Malaysia, 2010, 2012), and they also represent future Malaysian consumers (Sharipudin et al., 2020). The participants were informed that their participation in the study was completely voluntary and anonymous. The respondents were social media users who followed the accounts of SMIs.

Measures

The measuring items on the survey questionnaire were derived from previous research. All responses were measured using a 7-point Likert scale, with responses ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 7 (strongly agree).

We adapted measurement items from prior studies for the constructs. A total of 11 items from Yang et al. (2007) were used to assess the informational influence and normative influence constructs. We also adapted the trustworthiness (5 items), expertise (5 items), and attractiveness (5 items) constructs from Khong and Wu (2013). Further, we adapted a 4-item respect construct from Freeman and Chen (2015), and a 5-item similarity construct from Whittler and Spira (2002). Finally, three items to assess the purchase intention construct was adapted from Evans et al. (2017).

RESULTS

A total of 605 useable completed questionnaires was collected. The majority of respondents were aged 18–24 (90%), with Chinese contributing to a large number of respondents (50.2%) as compared to other ethnic groups such as Malays (42.1%), Indian (5%), and

others (2.6%). Meanwhile, a majority of respondents were females (85.6%) as compared to males (14.4%). For the majority of the respondents, Instagram was the most preferred social media platform (82.6%) as compared to other platforms.

As normality of data is essential, researchers are encouraged to perform tests before proceeding to multivariate analyses, especially for structural equation modelling (SEM) (Byrne, 2010; Hair et al., 2010). We conducted skewness and kurtosis analysis to ensure the normal distribution of the data (Hair et al., 2010; Kline, 2011). Kurtosis refers to the peakedness and flatness of the distribution (Byrne, 2010; Hair et al., 2010). In assessing the normality of data, the acceptable skewness and kurtosis index should be within ± 2 (Burns & Burns, 2008; Cameron, 2004). As the test results lay within the recommended range, we could confirm that the data was normally distributed (see Table 1).

Next, we assessed multicollinearity. The results revealed that variance inflation factors (VIF) values ranged 1.664 – 2.525, and were below the common threshold 5.0 (Hair et al., 2017). This suggests that there is no multicollinearity among the variables of the study.

Table 1. Normality for the variables

	N	Skewness Statistic	Std. Error	Kurtosis Statistic	Std. Error
TRST1	605	-0.691	0.099	0.214	0.198
TRST2	605	-0.353	0.099	-0.430	0.198
TRST3	605	-0.552	0.099	0.007	0.198
TRST4	605	-0.514	0.099	-0.128	0.198
TRST5	605	-0.618	0.099	-0.056	0.198
EXPERT1	605	-0.666	0.099	0.046	0.198
EXPERT2	605	-0.852	0.099	0.504	0.198
EXPERT3	605	-0.725	0.099	0.191	0.198
EXPERT4	605	-0.616	0.099	-0.158	0.198
EXPERT5	605	-0.826	0.099	0.534	0.198
ATTR1	605	-1.196	0.099	1.506	0.198
ATTR2	605	-0.903	0.099	0.504	0.198
ATTR3	605	-0.767	0.099	-0.033	0.198
ATTR4	605	-0.930	0.099	0.485	0.198
ATTR5	605	-0.940	0.099	0.680	0.198
RSPCT1	605	-0.836	0.099	1.124	0.198
RSPCT2	605	-0.672	0.099	0.318	0.198
RSPCT3	605	-0.928	0.099	1.054	0.198
RSPCT4	605	-0.876	0.099	0.710	0.198
SIM4	605	-0.635	0.099	0.406	0.198
SIM5	605	-0.760	0.099	0.284	0.198
INFO1	605	-0.913	0.099	0.832	0.198
INFO2	605	-0.874	0.099	0.676	0.198
INFO3	605	-1.016	0.099	1.116	0.198
NORM1	605	-0.733	0.099	0.268	0.198
NORM2	605	-0.822	0.099	0.293	0.198
NORM3	605	-0.546	0.099	-0.401	0.198
NORM4	605	-0.696	0.099	0.010	0.198

Table 1. (con't)

	N	Skewness Statistic	Std. Error	Kurtosis Statistic	Std. Error
NORM5	605	-0.729	0.099	0.343	0.198
NORM6	605	-0.497	0.099	-0.459	0.198
NORM7	605	-0.641	0.099	0.095	0.198
NORM8	605	-0.558	0.099	-0.359	0.198
PI1	605	-0.591	0.099	0.190	0.198
PI2	605	-0.494	0.099	-0.207	0.198
PI3	605	-0.492	0.099	-0.438	0.198

Note: TRST= trustworthiness; EXPERT = expertise; ATTR = attribute; RSPCT = respect; SIM = similarities; INFO = informative influence; NORM = normative influence

Multiple regression analysis was conducted to examine the relationship between the independent variables and dependent variables. As mentioned earlier, we employed the TEARS model and social influence constructs (i.e. informational, normative influence) as predictors to measure the influence of SMIs on purchase intention among young consumers.

Table 2 shows the regression result of the TEARS model and purchase intention. The results show that the model explained 44.7% of the variance and the model was a significant variable of purchase intention. A significant regression equation was found adjusted $R^2 = .447$, $F(5, 599) = 944.292$, $p = .000$. The results for the standardised coefficients value of the TEARS dimension are as follows; trustworthiness ($\beta = 0.141$, $p = .003$), expertise ($\beta = 0.176$, $p = .000$), attractiveness ($\beta = 0.185$, $p = .000$), respect ($\beta = 0.077$, $p = .111$), similarity ($\beta = 0.273$, $p = .000$) (see Table 2). Based on the results, four constructs were found to be significant predictors of purchase intention among young consumers. Hence, H1a, H1b, H1c, and H1e are supported, while H1d (i.e. respect) is not supported.

The results of social influence and purchase intention show that the model explained 39.1% of the variance, and the model was significant. A significant regression equation was found (adjusted $R^2 = 39.3\%$; $F(2, 602) = 2053.45$, $p = .000$). Both informational ($\beta = 0.228$, $p = .000$) and normative influence ($\beta = 0.463$, $p = .000$) have significant positive influence towards purchase intention. Therefore, H2a and H2b are supported. Based on the two models, the TEARS model explains the overall variance in the purchase intention dependent variable better than the social influence theory.

Table 2. Multiple regression analysis results

Predictor variable	Unstandardised Coefficients		Standardised Coefficients	<i>t</i>	<i>p</i>
	β	Std. Error	Beta		
Trustworthiness	.062	.026	.103	2.349	.019
Expertise	.102	.027	.161	3.801	.000
Attractiveness	.070	.023	.105	2.999	.003
Respect	.077	.048	.077	1.597	.111
Similarity	.121	.025	.198	5.236	.000
Informational	.290	.050	.228	5.735	.000
Normative	.215	.018	.463	11.665	.000

DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSION

Our study focused on how social media influencers and social influence have an impact on the purchase intention of Gen Z. We employed the TEARS model and social influence theory as the underpinning theories for our study. Our findings indicate that the trustworthiness, expertise, attractiveness, and similarity of SMIs have an impact on the purchase intention behaviour of consumers, particularly Gen Z. Our findings imply that the TEARS model predicted the purchase intention in the SMI context, with the exception of the “Respect” dimension. The findings are aligned with Chan et al.’s (2021) except for the ‘respect’ dimension. One of possible reasons why respect did not influence purchase intention in this study is probably because consumers knew that SMIs are paid to promote products and services. Given that SMIs have a financial incentive to review a product, consumers may regard this as conflict of interest and view their reviews as being unreliable.

Nonetheless, SMIs were found to be a strong predictor of purchase intention among young customers in our study. It is also possible that the TEARS Model, when compared to the social influence model, is a better predictor of purchase intent. The findings also demonstrate that the characteristics of SMIs continue to play a vital part in the decision-making process for young consumers. Thus, our study suggests that SMIs are essential for products and services to generate favourable outcomes, particularly among young customers.

Furthermore, in regard to practical implications, our study recommends that for marketing purposes, particularly for businesses, SMIs should be hired as brand ambassadors to increase sales. Undoubtedly, SMIs are a vital component in driving businesses to digital success. Notably, SMIs have their own set of skills for enticing people to buy things or instilling purchase intent in them. Further, in the aftermath of the COVID-19 pandemic, many individuals have aggressively moved on to purchasing products and services online.

Our research, like previous studies, has a number of limitations. As our study focused solely on Gen Z in Malaysia, future studies can include digital natives and digital immigrants across generations (e.g., Boomers, Gen X, and Gen Y) to expand the current findings and develop a better understanding of how the TEARS model operates across generations.

Another limitation is that this study relied on a survey. Respondents may have included various SMIs as well as external circumstances that may have influenced the study’s outcomes. As a result, more research should be conducted using an experimental approach to remove extraneous effects (e.g., nuisance).

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